

CITY UNIVERSITY OF HONG KONG, DEPARTMENT OF PUBLIC AND INTERNATIONAL AFFAIRS SEM A, A.Y. 2026/27

GLOBAL SOCIAL MOVEMENTS

PIA3142 | WEEK 1: INTRO/ORGANIZATIONAL MEETING

SOCIAL MOVEMENTS

SOME DEFINITIONS

“Social movements can be viewed as collective enterprises to establish a new order of life. They have their inception in the condition of unrest, and derive their motive power on one hand from dissatisfaction with the current form of life, and on the other hand, from wishes and hopes for a new scheme or system of living” (Blumer 1939).

“A social movement is a collectivity acting with some continuity to promote or resist a change in the society or organization of which it is a part. As a collectivity a movement is a group with indefinite and shifting membership and with leadership whose position is determined more by informal response of the members than by formal procedures for legitimating authority” (Turner & Killian 1972).

Social movements are "those organized efforts, on the part of excluded groups, to promote or resist changes in the structure of society that involve recourse to noninstitutional forms of political participation” (McAdam 1982).

Note the distinction between “social movement” and “social movement organization."

SOCIAL MOVEMENTS

SOME DEFINITIONS

Social movements and SMOs vary on many different dimensions. Among them:

* The causes they promote/espouse, or their goals (ranging from radical re-organization of society to narrowly defined issues);
* Their spatial/political organization (local, national, transnational);
* The nature of the actors/organizations/institutions on which social movements make their demands (inter-governmental orgs, non-governmental orgs, national governments, corporations);
* The methods/tactics they use.

KEY QUESTIONS

WE COVER IN THIS COURSE

- What does it take for people rebel against, or participate in social movements pressing demands on, authority?
- What are the main forces that drive them to get involved? Under what conditions are they likely to do so? How do they become willing to die for others?
- How does mass participation translate into social (sometimes revolutionary) change? What makes a given movement more or less successful?
- How does globalization affect domestic patterns of contentious politics?

Note that, as it is often the case in the social sciences, there is a lot of disagreement about what the right answers are.

KEY QUESTIONS

When do movements arise? What do the organizers do to mobilize people and motivate them to stay? How do they deal with fence-sitters and movement foes? Why do some movements scale up and become transnational? Why do movements dissipate? This course, designed as an overview of the social movements and contentious politics literature, will help you explore these questions. We will go over the primary theoretical building blocks, such as political opportunities, resource mobilization, and framing, and apply them to specific cases. Students will investigate movements of their choice for a research project, the results of which will be presented to the class.

—From the syllabus and the course outline